

So That They May Be Seen: A Walk Through White Cultural Institution Exclusion and Black Churches as Memory Workers in the 19th Century Philadelphia

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The Two Timelines

This article traces how Black churches in 19th-century Philadelphia functioned as museums, libraries, and cultural institutions when the city's white-run establishments either refused to evaluate Black intellectual work or denied Black people access.

1812 — A Library in a Church Basement

The Philadelphia Library Company for Colored Persons, founded in 1812, was housed in St. Thomas African Episcopal Church's basement. By 1842, it operated an organized winter lecture series with committees, secretaries, and dedicated meeting spaces—representing institutional architecture built from necessity.

A Grand Concert at St. Thomas in 1841 featured Francis Johnson conducting, with proceeds supporting the library. The program promised "Music. Science. Cultivation and extension."—scientific and cultural programming emerging from a church space.

1840 — A Telescope at the Franklin Institute, in Three Acts

Act One: The Announcement

October 7, 1840: The *Public Ledger* announced an "Unusual Mechanical Genius"—praising a telescope while using racial stereotypes before naming its maker: Robert B. Forten, son of wealthy sailmaker James Forten.

Act Two: The Correction

October 8, 1840: The paper corrected itself, using respectful language: "Mr. Robert B. Forten" and describing "intelligence, respectability, success." The Forten family's power secured this rapid correction.

Robert Bridges Forten had ground and polished the lenses himself on his nine-foot Newtonian telescope.

Act Three: The Non-Judgment

December 14, 1840: The Franklin Institute's annual exhibition awards report listed judgments across numerous categories—Fine Arts, Chemicals, Surgical Instruments, even a fourteen-year-old's miniature marble monument.

Then: "The weather." The judges could not judge Forten's telescope, which was "referred to the Committee on Science and the Arts." This referral led nowhere.

1841 — What Black Philadelphia Imagined Doing With the Telescope

Daniel Alexander Payne, an AME minister and future bishop (who had once lost partial sight looking at the sun during an eclipse), published a curriculum proposal in the *Colored American* for a Male and Female Seminary.

The curriculum included "Astronomy. Chemistry. Algebra. Greek. Hebrew. Moral Philosophy."—liberal arts higher education for Black students. Advanced scholars would keep an *Index Rerum*, a scholar's commonplace book.

Payne explained his poetry selections aimed to give readers "a right direction to their literary taste, and an elevated tone to their moral sensibilities," including Cowper, Thomson, Young, Milton, and biblical prophets.

Importantly: "whenever a class can be formed for that purpose." Payne indicated Robert Forten had agreed to deliver lectures on astronomy and give students telescopic views of the heavens—once an institutional container existed.

The contrast: In December 1840, the Franklin Institute refused to examine Forten's telescope. By April 1841, Black Philadelphia had imagined an institution to use it—with a curriculum, a teacher, and a vision of Black higher education.

September 1848 — A Wax Last Supper and a Resolution at Brick Wesley

An exhibition of wax statuary—"The Last Supper" and "The Trial and Crucifixion of the Saviour"—was restricted by color line, with "two days set apart for them" (Friday and Tuesday).

The *Pennsylvania Freeman* named what was happening: "None of Christ's dark-browed brethren were admitted. Against whose money they felt no prejudice."

Black Philadelphia called a meeting at Brick Wesley Church. On September 21, 1848, a large gathering adopted a unanimous resolution protesting this exclusion. The proprietors responded in print, telling Black people not to "seek to force themselves into a white audience" and to "appreciate a privilege."

The institution revealed its logic: exclusion as a bestowed favor, not denial of a right.

December 6, 1848 — The Vision Lands in the Boardroom

Visitors to the Institute for Colored Youth (ICY) managers' meeting made a proposal. ICY, founded by white Quakers in 1837, taught Black boys mechanical trades.

The visitors argued that "literary education was as important to Negroes as that of learning a trade" and suggested the apprenticed youth needed knowledge of "the higher branches...which would enable them to carry on their business more successfully and eventually to be prepared to instruct others in like manner."

This echoed Payne's 1841 vision—higher education that prepares students not just to work but to teach. The argument succeeded.

1856 — The Intellectuals Emerge

Within years, ICY's faculty included:

- Charles L. Reason (mathematician, poet, first Black professor at a predominantly white U.S. college)
- Ebenezer Don Carlos Bassett (ICY Principal, later first Black American diplomat)
- Octavius V. Catto (streetcar desegregation leader, assassinated 1871)
- Jacob C. White, Jr. (Philadelphia's first Black principal)
- Robert Campbell and others

November 1856 — Professor Campbell at the Franklin Institute

Robert Campbell, a science teacher at ICY, applied for a season ticket to the Franklin Institute's public lecture series. He complied with advertised terms and attended introductory lectures unmolested. When he applied for a ticket:

"I was told that no ticket could be sold to me. I inquired what the objections were, and received the very emphatic reply of 'color.'"

He wrote to the Institute's managers: "I was induced to seek access to your lectures by no other than a desire to be profitted by them."

A science teacher wanted to attend a science lecture in his own city—denied on racial grounds. The same institution that refused Forten's telescope in 1840 refused Campbell admission in 1856.

1856 — Aaron Roberts's Fire Apparatus

Aaron Roberts submitted a "Model of an Apparatus for Extinguishing Fires" to the Franklin Institute. The Committee praised it as "ingenious" and noted it would "supersede the ladder."

Yet the *Encyclopaedia Britannica* later credited the design to John S. Logan of Baltimore: "the first designs for a water tower were made by Aaron Roberts, a colored man of Philadelphia, in 1857, but none were ever constructed from this design."

Ingenuity acknowledged. Design shelved. Credit redirected.

1859 — "So That They May Be Seen"

Three years after his apparatus was reviewed but never built, Aaron Roberts wrote to the Banneker Institute of Philadelphia:

"as your object is to keep Records of all the inventions that [are] got up by our people so that they may be seen."

Roberts understood: white institutions would not preserve his name. The Black-run Banneker Institute would.

The vocabulary recurred across decades: *Records. Higher branches. To be seen. To instruct others.* Black Philadelphia worked out the same problem in consistent language—how to preserve, credit, and transmit Black intellectual work when white institutions refused evaluation.

The answer: **Build our own.**

1852 — Wonders of the Microscopic World

A church hosted a science demonstration. November 9, 1852: the *Public Ledger* advertised a hydro-oxygen microscope

exhibition—cutting-edge projection technology showing massively magnified microscopic specimens—at a church. Ten cents. Benefit of the church.

Meanwhile, the Franklin Institute and Academy of Natural Science were open to white visitors only.

1853 — The Chinese Museum

Robert Purvis's son escorted Sarah Remond (an emerging anti-slavery lecturer from Salem) and Annie Wood (sister of Mary Virginia Wood Forten, wife of the telescope-maker) to the Chinese Museum. They were turned away solely for their color.

The Purvises sued in alderman's court and lost.

1897 — Stereopticon Civil War History

Thirty-two years after Appomattox, as the *Lost Cause* narrative erased Black soldiers from Civil War history, a church hosted resistance.

April 30, 1897: First African Presbyterian Church presented "Grand War Scenery. The Negro Soldier in the Late Civil War" under stereopticon illumination—projected-image technology, 1897's closest thing to cinema. Twenty cents at the door.

The church mounted a multimedia history exhibition refusing the *Lost Cause* in real time.

1908 — Mother Bethel Finds a Museum

August 10, 1908: Mother Bethel AME Church's Allen Guard heard a speech arguing it was "time that we began to gather in this church pictures and historical relics of the founders of the A.M.E. Church."

A resolution followed: the church would "Collect...Care for...Preserve...Articles of historical value...A room...To be known as...Museum."

A committee. A collections mandate. A named museum inside a Black church—decades before what people now consider Black history museums.

ca. 1910 — The Children of Mary Virginia Wood's Family

An image of children related to the Wood-Webb family (Mary Virginia Wood's relatives—descendants of the telescope-maker's household) is held by the Library Company of Philadelphia.

The irony: the Library Company that excluded the family in the 19th century now holds their portrait in trust.

The Pattern

Across the documented timeline:

1812: Black Library Company founded in church basement; white Library Company operates separately

1840: Forten's telescope displayed at Franklin Institute but not judged

1841: Payne publishes vision for Black seminary; Forten agrees to teach astronomy "whenever a class can be formed"

1842: Library Company winter lecture series at church

1848 (September): Brick Wesley hosts protest against segregated wax exhibition access

1848 (December): Visitors persuade ICY managers to add higher education

1852: Microscope demonstration at church

1856: Campbell denied Franklin Institute ticket with "the very emphatic reply of 'color'"; Roberts's fire apparatus praised but never built

1859: Roberts submits invention to Banneker Institute "so that they may be seen"

1897: Stereopticon Civil War exhibition at church

1908: Mother Bethel founds museum

What This Means for How We Talk About Museums

When people ask when Black museum work began in Philadelphia, institutions often point to mid-20th-century origins. But the beginning was 1812 in a church basement.

It was Payne in 1841 imagining Black students with Forten's telescope. It was December 1848 visitors arguing for "the higher

branches." It was the 1852 microscope show, 1897 stereopticon exhibition, 1908 museum founding at Mother Bethel.

It was also September 1848's refusal at Brick Wesley—Black Philadelphia standing in a church rejecting the demand to "appreciate a privilege" of segregated admission to white cultural spaces.

The refusal and the building happened simultaneously, in the same circles, same year, same city.

And it was Aaron Roberts in 1859: "keep Records of all the inventions that are got up by our people so that they may be seen."

That sentence encompasses the entire narrative—keeping records, showing what Black people created, ensuring visibility when white institutions provided neither examination nor credit.

Forten's telescope was "deposited" and "referred," never examined. Roberts's apparatus was deemed "ingenious" and built by someone else. Campbell received "the very emphatic reply of 'color.'"

Black Philadelphia built another city. They held it in church basements, literary institutes, Sunday school stereopticon shows, and an AME museum named for Richard Allen. They were always museums. Always libraries. Always lecture halls and concert venues and historical societies.

They were simply inside the churches and literary societies—and in the seminaries that lived first as visions in Black newspapers before acquiring buildings.

"This is a restorative justice piece. It is the work of keeping records. So that they may be seen."

Images

- Forten's Telescope (nine feet long Newtonian telescope) — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_de0b485d42a64678973b1228bc416106~mv2.jpg
- Article from 07 Oct 1840 Public Ledger — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_f01fda0eb00b4e0aaa870a226f0133cb~mv2.png
- Article from 08 Oct 1840 Public Ledger (correction) — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_8c0a0e5b6ae94fe493cb2601503a9896~mv2.jpg
- Article from 14 Dec 1840 The Philadelphia Inquirer — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_73e0fd07de5b4cdab6e6e1515f96ea25~mv2.png
- Bishop Daniel A. Payne portrait — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_a871b1a44801453090dd3df089aeac7b~mv2.png
- Colored American April 3, 1841 curriculum — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_9291a58748a044eb95a59da16d1cb5bc~mv2.png
- Colored American April 3, 1841 (continued) — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_076e4262ea22486a88cfc7ab22613b8e~mv2.png
- Article from 22 Sep 1848 Public Ledger (wax exhibition) — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_3978de463f804a2aa9f48a6bd476107a~mv2.png
- The Pennsylvania Freeman September 28, 1848 — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_9ebe04120ff84b478c96a640d71efbee~mv2.png
- Pennsylvania Freeman September 28, 1848 resolution — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_e20e8a15734e49aa91c3a1b6e1bd1d42~mv2.png
- Article from 26 Sep 1848 Public Ledger (proprietor response) — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_a190d40ae79e4f1cb4d4fe3ef27bf3c8~mv2.png
- Brick Wesley location photograph — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_fee4509867a748158ba7920014d27428~mv2.png
- ICY Faculty group portrait 1860s — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_8b47566123714cc0ad19bfcae39c5b9c~mv2.jpg
- Robert Campbell letter page 1 — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_4bdb5957242643f988a2ad85e2e3c313~mv2.png
- Robert Campbell letter page 2 — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_5750b187fd46405b8a943c9ba7e00845~mv2.png
- Robert Campbell portrait — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_a17aa8b8e1cd4580a9b8aebaf455a995~mv2.png
- Article from 09 Nov 1852 Public Ledger (microscope) —

- https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_8783bf6811634d9187510e2ed65c3f47~mv2.png
- Hydro-oxygen microscope illustration —
https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_efd124b55d244a9c9aaad8b5aa377c6e~mv2.png
 - Sarah Remond portrait — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_02b7d934f1c34444bbdb7771e556f32~mv2.png
 - Mary Virginia Wood Forten memory album note —
https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_f7950f866fb34bc6aa63575ad73b1982~mv2.jpg
 - Aaron Roberts fire apparatus illustration —
https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_bd09a52fae1d4a2e8a8269c9748128ca~mv2.png
 - Journal of the Franklin Institute, 1856 (Roberts apparatus review) —
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 - Encyclopaedia Britannica entry (Aaron Roberts) —
https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_0ffa18d735aa4d308b6813ccf80cd5e4~mv2.png
 - Grand War Scenery handbill, April 30, 1897 —
https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_031699219c2e4eeabf47d8093a8d2c9a~mv2.jpg
 - Civil War exhibition image — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_3ae92abfeeb540fc94f6dfa642d9ef0b~mv2.jpg
 - Mother Bethel Historical Commission minutes, August 10, 1908 —
https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_29773d34505a45d886d6fcd245dfe78~mv2.png
 - Wood-Webb family children portrait ca. 1910 —
https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_8504a46062e140af89f62abff783eeaa~mv2.jpg
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